5.1 Introduction to Information Literacy

Week 4 introduces the topic of information literacy, which deals with how to find and use information, including how to evaluate sources and use them appropriately in an academic or professional setting. This is a skill that demonstrates academic and professional integrity, and it is necessary to master this skill in your role as a student and professional. Watch the following video to learn about why research is important in various facets of your life and the value of finding the most relevant and credible information.

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Figure 5.1.1: Why Research Is Important

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Transcript

5.2 Introducing the University Library

Information Literacy

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We can all relate to taking out our phones and using Google to find information. It happens every day. So far this week, you've been learning how to assess the quality of the information you find on the web. What if there was a shortcut to finding quality information that you could feel confident using to support your ideas? It turns out, there is! The University Library is a resource available to University of Phoenix students that contains that quality information. Take a look at the following video to learn how the University Library stacks up to Google.

Figure 5.2.1: Google vs. The University Library

Google vs. The University Library

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02:10

Transcript

The information and resources in the University Library will contribute to your academic success and can be very valuable as you complete your coursework. So that you can get the full benefit of these resources, let's learn more about how to actually find information in the University Library.

Figure 5.2.2: University Library

University Library

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Library Search Strategies

The University Library contains a wealth of information but searching for information in the Library is different from your typical internet search. In this video, faculty member Brad Carroll gives you quick and valuable tips for finding information in the University Library.

Figure 5.2.3: Searching the University Library

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Searching the University Library

03:16

Transcript

As Brad mentioned, finding articles in the University Library takes a little practice. Don't get discouraged. You will have plenty of opportunities to develop your library search skills throughout your University of Phoenix degree program.

You can learn more about effectively searching EBSCOhost, one of the University Library's most popular databases, by watching the following video:

Figure 5.2.4: Search Strategies for EBSCOHost

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EBSCOhost Basic Search - Tutorial

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For detailed instructions on finding information in the library, visit the GEN/201 Week 4 University Library page and click on "Develop a Search Strategy" in the Resource section. The tips on this page will help you with choosing a topic, searching for sources, and improving your search results.

PARTICIPATION ACTIVITY | 5.2.1: University Library

1) When you are looking for sources, it is important to ensure that your results contain credible and reliable articles. To do this, first, you open the University Library home page. Next, you type your search terms in the search box. There are many options for you to select from to help narrow your search results. Which one of the actions below will help you to make sure the articles you find are scholarly and academic?

- Click on "Search"
- Check the "Peer-Reviewed" box
- Click on "Advanced Search" and use the filter fields to narrow the search
- Click on "Full Text"

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2) Don is asked to write a research paper on a topic of his choice, and he is

interested in researching the controversy surrounding keeping animals in zoos. Don is a bit overwhelmed on how to start collecting his research in the University Library. Which of the following search words would allow for more targeted results on this topic so that Don can gather helpful information to guide his research?

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- "Zoos"
- "Animals"
- "Zoo animals"
- "Zoo animals" AND "Advantages and disadvantages"

3) Your classmate really enjoyed an article and wants to share it with you. She said that the article was unbiased, credible, and would be relevant for a project you are working on. She sends you the APA-formatted reference below.

Smith, R., & Mulligan, T. (2019). Cars and Trucks. *On the Road*. 24(3), 130–135.

What is the title of the article that your friend wants to share with you?

- Cars and Trucks
- Mulligan
- Smith
- *On the Road*

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4) Who is the author of the article your classmate is sharing and what year was it written?

- Mulligan, T. (2019)
- Smith, R., & Mulligan, T. (2019)

- Cars and Trucks, 2019
- *On the Road*, 2019

5.3 Using the Internet for Research

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Although the University Library should be your go-to place for conducting research, there will be occasions when you will need to research content on the internet. Everyone has some level of experience researching on the internet. Whether it's the best rate on a hotel room or a good chicken recipe, the internet provides us with access to an endless supply of information. Unfortunately, not everything we encounter on the web is accurate. Take this short survey to gauge your current level of internet savvy.

PARTICIPATION ACTIVITY 5.3.1: What Do You Already Know About Internet Searching?

1) Nothing found on the internet is reliable.

- True
- False

2) Wikipedia is reliable enough to use as a reference in a paper for school.

- True
- False

3) A *.com* site does not have reliable information because it is a commercial site.

- True
- False

4) Only *.com* sites are commercial sites.

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- True
- False

5) Information presented objectively, without overuse of opinion, is more likely to be valid.

- True
- False

6) A print source is always more reliable than the internet.

- True
- False

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Internet Search Strategies

Finding reliable, accurate, and credible information is a skill that students develop to be more effective in class, at work, and at home. The following are general internet search strategies recommended by the University of California Berkeley Library (2006) to help you get started when you have to investigate a topic.

- **Analyze the topic to be searched**: Before searching, think about what you are looking for. The more specific the parameters, the better the results. What words or phrases are unique to the topic? What words are commonly linked, but unrelated to the topic? For example, you may be interested in studying video games, which is a general topic. You can make it more specific, like the effects of video games on teenagers, or even more specific, the positive or negative effects of video games on the brain development of teenagers. These different parameters will produce different search results.
- **Choose the right starting place**: Using the proper search tool is almost as important as using the right keywords or phrases. Familiarize yourself with the tools on the web and how they can be most efficiently used. For example, Google, Bing, or Wikipedia will generate a lot of different results that may not be suitable for scholarly use, while Google™ Scholar will bring up articles that are more academic.
- **Learn as you go and vary your approach**: Making assumptions about the topic can limit what you find. Read through the results to see where they might lead you. Your browser's *back* button will return you to the original list of results.
- **Do not get bogged down with an ineffective strategy**: Use a different search tool, start a new search with different keywords, or position the search words differently to increase effectiveness.
- **Return to previous strategies better informed**: Once you gain information from searching, apply it to the subject and begin a new search with more insight.

Finding Good Information

The credibility of a website is always important to consider, especially when doing academic research or writing academic papers. In fact, credibility is crucial in academia. However, the need for credible information is not limited to school. As you can imagine, the ability to identify, locate, evaluate, and use credible information to solve problems is an essential job and life skill.

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The truth is anyone can post information on the internet. BobJones.com, written by Bob Jones, might contain information about the Civil War, but the reader may not know that Bob is an expert on the Civil War. Accurately determining the reliability and validity of websites is an essential skill when deciding to use an internet source in an academic paper.

Consider the following questions when searching internet sources for information to use in an academic paper.

Table 5.3.1: Questions to Consider

What is the website extension?	Who is the author?
A website address usually includes "www" followed by a period (called a dot), followed by an extension name (also called a domain name). The reliability of a website can frequently be determined by the domain or extension name. The most reliable extensions include the following: • **.edu:** a school or other educational institution site • **.gov:** a government site • **.mil:** a military site Three other common extensions may or may not be reliable. You will need to investigate further to determine the reliability of websites with the following extensions: • **.org:** a noncommercial site that is used for nonprofit organizations, foundations, cultural institutions, and other organizations that perform charitable work • **.com:** a site that is for business and commercial organizations and probably should not be used for academic research • **.net:** a site that is usually reserved for network providers and probably should not be used for academic research Other less common extensions also exist, with varying degrees of reliability.	Authors may be clearly identified as individuals or organizations. **Named author:** A person with a background or credentials in the subject of interest will be easy to cross-reference on other internet searches to determine credibility. The head of the oncology department at a major research hospital, for example, will be a more reliable source for cancer information than Jimmy Smith, a florist from Kalamazoo. **Organization as author:** When no specific author is listed, the sponsoring organization is the implied author. Scrutinize the name of the organization carefully. A site sponsored by a major research hospital will probably be more reliable than "Jimmy Smith's Direct Discount Meds."
What is the publication date?	**What source material is provided?**
The publication and copyright date should be recent, ideally within the last three years. Even	Reliable websites offer clear indications of supporting evidence and documentation,

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in the case of historical information that does not change, a reliable website will be regularly maintained and updated.	whether in the form of links, directives, authors' credentials, or references. Sites that do not link, refer, or reference any other sites or information are often unreliable or biased sources.

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Evaluating Web Sources

Internet sources may pass initial tests for reliability and credibility, but they still may be biased sources. Because anyone can publish to the internet, it is not always obvious when a site's main purpose is advertisement, sales, or propaganda. Be aware of any possible agenda or hidden purpose from the site or the author presenting the information.

Because they often exist for commercial purposes, ***.com*** and ***.net*** sites usually attempt to sell the consumer a product or service, but this fact alone does not call the reliability into question. Be aware of focus. For example, is the viewer bombarded by requests for money or links to purchase goods and services, or are such opportunities and links simply made available? Does a product or viewpoint seem to be presented as the only possible solution, or does the information discuss both pros and cons clearly and objectively?

Websites to avoid

Wikipedia.org: Wikipedia is an online encyclopedia that is written and edited by volunteers. Wikipedia is not suitable for academic research because anyone can post or change information on the site. As Wikipedia's About page states (2020), "Wikipedia is written largely by amateurs. Those with expert credentials are given no additional weight. Wikipedia is also not subject to any peer review" (para. 2.5). Therefore, Wikipedia should not be considered a reliable source.

About.com: a commercial site that contains content written by "Guides" who are experts in their fields (About.com: For Educators & Librarians, n.d.). About.com should not be used as a reference without substantiating the content through a more reliable source. However, once a reliable source from a suitable domain (.edu, .gov, or .mil) has been located, it will be unnecessary to use About.com. Use websites such as Wikipedia and About.com only for background information to point you to more reliable sources.

Blogs: sites created by individuals. Blogs can be created by reputable and knowledgeable subject matter experts or by anyone wanting to post information on the internet. Credible authors seek to prove their reliability to readers. They often point to standard sources, which are better sources for research.

The CRAAP Method

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So far, you have been learning about how and where to look to find information, as well as the importance of using credible sources in your assignments. One popular way to evaluate information is to apply the CRAAP method. This involves asking yourself questions about the Currency, Relevancy, Authority, Accuracy, and Purpose of a source. Take a few minutes to learn more about the CRAAP method by reading "Evaluate Sources" from the University Library. As you read, think about how you can apply the concepts presented in this article to your Wk 4 – Finding and Using Information Worksheet assignment.

1) When we examine the results from a web search, we have to consider if the information is credible or not. Which one of the following statements is accurate about credible research?

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- There is no way to determine if information is credible or not.
- All information on the internet is credible and reliable.
- Credible and reliable research should be from a source that has proven expertise on the subject.
- How current a source is does not factor into whether the information is credible and reliable.

2) Some website domains are restricted for specific types of organizations, so a website's domain name (or extension name) can provide clues about the type of information that will be found on the site. Why would you want to look at the website's extension (e.g., .edu, .com, .org, .mil, .gov, .net) when conducting research?

- A website's extension tells you about the information's publisher.
- A website's extension tells you what the topic of the website's content is.
- A website's extension tells you when the website was last updated.
- A website's extension tells you what state the information was published in.

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3) Sometimes performing a quick web search is helpful when brainstorming ideas. However, when writing scholarly or academic papers, it is important to make sure that the references you use are credible and scholarly. The scholarly community has rigorous guidelines for credibility and values articles that are published in academic journals and are peer reviewed. Which one of the following sources would be best to use when searching for scholarly articles while doing academic research?

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- Wikipedia
- Google Scholar
- A blog written by a medical doctor
- A review written on Amazon.com

4) Isaiah is searching for sources for an essay he is writing on in-demand careers in the field of information technology. He finds an article in the University Library that provides information on careers in the field of information technology. The article was published in a peer-reviewed journal in 2001. Should Isaiah use this article as a research source for his essay?

- Yes, Isaiah should use the article because it is relevant, accurate, and current.
- No, Isaiah should not use the article because it is relevant and accurate, but not current.
- Yes, Isaiah should use the article because he found it in the University Library and all sources in the library are reliable.

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- No, Isaiah should not use the article because it does not relate to the topic he is writing about.

5) Danica is presenting at an office meeting and is searching for research sources to back up the ideas she is pitching to her boss and colleagues. She finds a website that she can verify is current, relevant, and informative. However, the name of the author is not listed on the website. What steps should Danica take next?

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- Use the website as a source anyway. No one will notice.
- Use the website as a source but disclose to her boss that she cannot identify the author of the site.
- Discard the website because it may be unreliable.
- Take time to look at the URL to see if it reveals anything about the author or source and look to see if there is a publisher name or email address listed on the site.

5.4 References

About Wikipedia. (2020). In *Wikipedia*. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Wikipedia:About

<u>*YOU HAVE NOW COMPLETED ALL OF THE READINGS FOR WEEK 4***</u>**

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